

FAMILY ELDERCARE — CONSOLIDATED VENDOR QUESTIONS AND RESPONSES

Request for Proposal: Co-Managed Information Technology Services

Issued By	Key Dates
Family Eldercare 1700 Rutherford Lane, Austin, TX 78754 www.familyeldercare.org	Vendor questions due: September 22, 2026 Q&A issued: October 2, 2026 Proposals due: October 23, 2026, 5:00 PM CT Anticipated contract start: February 1, 2027

Purpose

This document consolidates the written questions received by the September 22, 2026 deadline and the Organization’s responses, as provided in RFP §8. Questions have been combined and edited for clarity, grouped by subject, and are not attributed to individual respondents.

Where a response states a pricing assumption, clarification, or expectation, respondents should rely on it in preparing their proposals. Except as clarified herein, all terms and conditions of the RFP and Addendum No. 1 remain in full force and effect.

Attachment A (Pricing Summary Form), or an equivalent reproduction of it, must be completed and placed at the front of each pricing submission (see 1.6).

Questions regarding this document may be directed to the Point of Contact at procurement@familyeldercare.org.

1. Procurement Process & Proposal Format

1.1 Q&A publication date

The website's response instructions referenced October 23 for Q&A responses. Which date applies?

Response: Consolidated responses to all vendor questions will be issued by **October 2, 2026** (RFP §8). The website has been corrected. Proposals remain due **October 23, 2026, 5:00 PM CT**.

1.2 Page limit

Which elements count against the 15-page limit? This covers the cover letter, table of contents, addendum acknowledgment, Transition Plan, staff bios and org chart, references, and compliance attestations. Is there a limit on appendices?

Response: RFP §5 limits proposals to 15 pages “excluding pricing details, appendices, and certifications.” The following do **not** count toward the limit: the cover letter, table of contents, addendum acknowledgment, pricing forms (§6), insurance certificates, certifications and compliance attestations, reference contact information, staff résumés, and organizational charts. The narrative sections required by §5 **do** count, including the Company Overview, Approach to Co-Managed Service Delivery, and Transition Plan. Appendices have no page limit but should stay supplementary. Evaluators will score the 15-page narrative.

1.3 Forms, signature, and addendum acknowledgment

Is a specific response form, cover sheet, or signature page required? Must the proposal be signed? Is a specific addendum acknowledgment form required?

Response: No specific response form is required. The proposal should be signed by an individual authorized to bind the respondent. A written statement in the proposal acknowledging Addendum No. 1 and any later addenda is sufficient. An email reply is neither required nor sufficient, as noted in the Addendum distribution.

1.4 Submission file size

Is there a maximum attachment size or a preferred secure transfer method?

Response: Submit a single PDF to procurement@familyeldercare.org (RFP §9). If the file exceeds 25 MB, email the Point of Contact at least two business days before the deadline to arrange a secure upload link. Submission is timely when the file is received, not when the link is requested.

1.5 Multiple options

May a respondent submit two options?

Response: Each respondent must submit one primary proposal with a single Total Three-Year Cost of Ownership (RFP §6). That figure is the only one scored under the cost formula (§7).

Alternates may be included as clearly labeled optional line items, for example a different hardware ownership model or an optional scope shift under §3.5. They will be considered during evaluation and negotiation but will not be scored under the cost formula.

1.6 Pricing template

Will Family Eldercare publish a standard pricing template or workbook?

Response: Yes. A Pricing Summary Form is provided as Attachment A to this Q&A. Respondents need not complete the published document itself; they may reproduce the form in their own format, provided it includes every line item in Attachment A, in the same order and with the same labels. The completed form must appear at the front of the pricing submission, followed by supporting detail under headings that match the RFP §6 bullets. The form summarizes the §6 elements and does not replace any of them. The three-year total on the form is the Total Three-Year Cost of Ownership scored under RFP §7.

1.7 References

May references include current clients? When will references be contacted? Are reference letters acceptable?

Response: Yes. Current clients qualify as “clients served within the last three years” (RFP §5). Under Addendum 1 §1.2, the three required references must be clients the prime itself has served. The Organization expects to contact references for finalists only, during or after the finalist interview period (Nov 4–13). Written reference letters may be included as a supplement but do not replace contact information.

1.8 Site walkthroughs

Would Family Eldercare offer an optional pre-proposal walkthrough of the main office, Pecan Gardens, and Lyons Gardens?

Response: No pre-proposal walkthroughs will be offered, for fairness to all respondents and consistent with the pre-award discovery restriction noted in RFP §5. The Organization anticipates offering site walkthroughs to respondents selected for finalist interviews, so that finalists can refine cost assumptions before a final contract offer.

1.9 Finalist interviews

Are interviews scored separately, used to adjust written scores, or for clarification only? Will every responsive respondent be interviewed? Are interviews virtual or on-site? Can pricing assumptions be adjusted at that stage?

Response: Interviews are not a separate scored factor. The Organization “reserves the right to conduct interviews or request clarifications prior to final scoring” (RFP §7), and information gathered in interviews may inform scores on the existing factors. Interviews will be held with a

shortlist of top-ranked responsive respondents, not with every respondent. Interviews will be held virtually; finalists will be offered site walkthroughs separately (see 1.8). Pricing is evaluated as submitted. The Organization reserves the right to negotiate final terms with one or more respondents (RFP §10), which may include revised pricing after finalist walkthroughs.

1.10 Further addenda

Will more addenda follow the Oct 2 Q&A, and is there a cutoff?

Response: The Organization does not currently anticipate further addenda after the consolidated Q&A. Any addendum issued after October 13, 2026 will be limited to schedule changes or will come with a corresponding extension of the proposal deadline.

1.11 Federal certification forms

Will Family Eldercare provide the 2 CFR 200 Appendix II certification forms? Does the §200.216 attestation cover equipment already installed?

Response: Certification forms (Byrd Anti-Lobbying, debarment and suspension, EEO, and 2 CFR 200.216) will be provided to the selected respondent during contract negotiation (RFP §10). Proposals need only affirm willingness to execute them. The §200.216 attestation covers equipment and services the respondent will provide or procure under this engagement, not equipment already installed at Organization sites.

2. Eligibility, Qualifications & Teaming

2.1 Three years of continuous operation

Must the prime entity itself meet the three-year requirement, or can it be met through principals' prior experience or a teaming partner? When is it measured?

Response: This was answered in Addendum No. 1. The prime must independently meet the three-year requirement (§1.2). Qualifying predecessor time counts (§1.1). Alternative evidence is not accepted as a substitute (§1.3). The requirement is measured as of the proposal deadline, so the prime must have operated continuously as an MSP since on or before **October 23, 2023** (§2). Principals' experience and a disclosed teaming partner's experience are still evaluated under the scored criteria (§1.3).

2.2 Teaming and subcontracting

Are prime/subcontractor arrangements permitted? Which qualifications must the prime meet independently? May a subcontractor perform on-site support, Tier 3, network administration,

SOC/IR, BDR, and transition work? Must subcontractors carry their own insurance, screening, BAA, and SAM registration?

Response: This was answered in Addendum No. 1 §1.2. Arrangements are permitted. The prime must meet every minimum qualification except On-site Capability, which may be met through a **named Austin-area subcontractor**; the prime stays accountable for §3.3 response times. Subcontractors may perform the listed functions, but the prime must perform a material portion of the §3 services itself, including account management and escalation. Subcontractors do not need SAM.gov registration or a direct BAA with the Organization. They must not be excluded, must be covered by the prime's CGL and Cyber/E&O insurance, must meet the background screening requirement, and must sign a subcontractor BAA with the prime where they handle PHI.

2.3 Sub-subcontracting

May a disclosed subcontractor subcontract further ("sub-sub")?

Response: Yes, but only if each lower-tier subcontractor is disclosed in the proposal with the same detail required by Addendum 1 §1.2: identity, task-level scope, and location. Lower-tier subcontractors are subject to the same requirements as first-tier subcontractors, including the U.S. access requirements in Addendum 1 §3. Federal flow-down provisions apply "to subcontracts at every tier" (Addendum 1 §1.4). Adding or substituting a lower-tier subcontractor after award requires the Organization's written consent.

2.4 Local presence

Does "local presence" require a brick-and-mortar Austin office? May on-site capability be met through a combination of the respondent's own personnel and a named Austin-area subcontractor?

Response: No. RFP §4 requires "demonstrated capacity to provide on-site support within the Austin metropolitan area within the response times in Section 3.3." A physical office is not required. Respondents may meet this requirement through their own Austin-area personnel, a named Austin-area subcontractor (Addendum 1 §1.2), or a combination of both. In every case, the prime remains accountable for the on-site response times in §3.3.

3. Personnel Location & Remote Administrative Access (Addendum 1 §3)

3.1 Scope of the U.S. requirement

Does the U.S.-based and U.S.-origin requirement extend to (a) third-party SOC, NOC, or MDR providers monitoring on the MSP's behalf; (b) after-hours or overflow help desk delivered by a

partner; (c) software and platform vendors' support staff; and (d) monitoring-only staff who see alerts but hold no credentials?

Response: Addendum 1 §3 applies to “the prime, to each subcontractor, and to all personnel of either who hold or exercise administrative access to Organization systems.” Accordingly:

- (a) A third-party SOC, NOC, or MDR provider working on the MSP's behalf is a subcontractor and must be disclosed under Addendum 1 §1.2. Where its personnel hold or exercise administrative access, they must be U.S.-based and access must originate in the U.S. Administrative access includes containment actions such as isolating an endpoint, disabling an account, or resetting credentials, because §3 defines administrative access to include “endpoint and server administration” and “account creation and modification.”
- (b) After-hours or overflow help desk partners are subcontractors. Because help desk work includes password and MFA resets, which Addendum 1 §3 expressly treats as administrative access, these personnel must be U.S.-based.
- (c) Personnel of software and platform vendors (for example EDR, backup, or RMM vendors) acting under their own vendor support terms are not subcontractors under this engagement. However, the MSP may not grant them standing administrative access to Organization systems. Any case-specific access must be disclosed to and approved by the IT & Data Manager.
- (d) Personnel who only view alerts or telemetry and hold no credentials or ability to make changes do not exercise administrative access. Their country of work must still be disclosed under Addendum 1 §3 (“each country from which services under this engagement will be performed—including help desk, monitoring, and subcontracted work”).

3.2 Data residency and geographic redundancy

Must backup data, logs, and monitoring telemetry be stored in U.S. regions, or within Texas? Is geographic redundancy for cloud backups preferred or required?

Response: Addendum 1 governs where administrative access originates, not where data is stored. The Organization intends to require, in the final agreement, that backup data and data in any system that may hold protected health information be stored in U.S. regions; respondents should propose only U.S.-region storage for those systems. Storage within Texas is not required. At least one backup copy held in a region geographically separate from the Organization's Austin sites is strongly preferred and will be considered under the Cybersecurity, privacy, and compliance safeguards factor. For each tool proposed, respondents must state the storage region for backup data, logs, and telemetry; the number of backup copies and their regions; and whether copies are immutable.

3.3 Offshore subcontractor eligibility

Could a non-U.S. provider participate as a subcontractor or delivery partner to a qualified U.S. prime?

Response: Under Addendum 1 §3: a non-U.S. subcontractor's personnel may not hold or exercise administrative access to Organization systems, including password and MFA resets. Any services they perform must be disclosed by country, and the proposal must attest that remote administrative access originates solely in the U.S.

3.4 Travel exception

(Statement) *An individual temporarily outside the U.S. would need a temporary travel exception.*

Response: Correct. Addendum 1 §3 provides a written-approval process. The request must identify the individual, travel dates, country, and business reason, and must be made in advance. Absent approval, that individual's administrative access must be suspended for the duration of travel.

3.5 Just-in-time elevation and U.S.-hosted administrative environments

Would just-in-time privileged access (e.g., Microsoft Entra Privileged Identity Management) by a non-U.S.-based engineer be permitted? Would the requirement be met if a non-U.S.-based engineer performs administrative work through a hardened, U.S.-hosted administrative environment or privileged access workstation, protected by PIM, MFA, Conditional Access, and session logging? If neither is permitted, may non-U.S.-based personnel perform non-privileged help desk, monitoring, troubleshooting, documentation, and engineering functions, with any activity requiring elevation escalated to U.S.-based personnel?

Response: No, in both of the first two cases. Addendum 1 §3 requires that *all* remote administrative access to Organization systems originate within the United States. The “standing administrative access” language determines which personnel must be U.S.-based; it does not exempt temporary or just-in-time access from the origin requirement, and §3 applies to all personnel who “hold or exercise” administrative access. Origin is determined by the physical location of the individual exercising access, not the location of the host, jump server, or workstation through which the session passes. This is why §3 provides a written-approval process for named individuals temporarily outside the United States. Controls such as PIM, MFA, Conditional Access, and session logging are valued and will be considered under the Cybersecurity, privacy, and compliance safeguards factor, but they do not substitute for this requirement.

Non-U.S.-based personnel may perform functions that do not involve administrative access as defined in §3, provided those functions and the countries from which they are performed are disclosed in the proposal. This excludes password and MFA resets, which §3 expressly treats as

administrative access, including during supplemental coverage periods under RFP §3.2. It also excludes troubleshooting or engineering performed with elevated rights, such as remote sessions or scripts run with administrative privileges through RMM tooling. Monitoring without credentials or the ability to make changes is permitted (see 3.1(d)). Activity requiring elevation must be escalated to and performed by U.S.-based personnel, and the respondent must maintain sufficient U.S.-based staffing to meet RFP §3.3 response times at all times (Addendum 1 §3, Continuity of coverage).

4. Compliance, Screening, Insurance & Records

4.1 Form of compliance evidence

Is SOC 2 Type II required? Would ISO 27001, NIST CSF alignment with HIPAA safeguards, or tooling vendors' SOC 2 reports suffice? Will respondents without SOC 2 be scored as deficient, given the 70-point floor?

Response: SOC 2 is not a minimum qualification. RFP §5 asks for “documented compliance with relevant IT security standards (e.g., SOC 2, HIPAA, NIST CSF),” supported by “copies or attestations.” The following are all acceptable evidence: a SOC 2 Type I or II report, ISO/IEC 27001 certification, or a written attestation of NIST CSF alignment with documented HIPAA Security Rule safeguards and supporting policy evidence. Evidence is evaluated on its substance under the Cybersecurity, privacy, and compliance safeguards factor (§7). An independent third-party attestation of the respondent’s own controls will generally carry more weight than self-attestation. Tooling vendors’ SOC 2 reports may be submitted as supporting evidence, but they describe those vendors’ controls, not the respondent’s.

The RFP has no “Section 5.7” and no “equivalent assurance package” provision. The requirement is as stated in §5.

4.2 Background screening

What screening scope, vendor, lookback period, re-screening cadence, and documentation format are required, and when must screening be completed?

Response: RFP §4 requires respondents to “provide proof or permit criminal background screening” of all personnel with administrative access or physical access to Organization facilities, regardless of employer (Addendum 1 §1.2). At a minimum, screening must include a seven-year county and federal criminal search, national criminal database search, and national sex offender registry search. It may be performed by the respondent’s own screening provider. Screening must be completed before an individual is assigned to the engagement, not before proposal submission, and renewed at each contract anniversary. Screening results need not be submitted with proposals. Before access is granted, the selected respondent must provide a written attestation listing each screened individual, the screening date, and the scope.

4.3 Insurance beyond minimums

Will the agreement require additional insured status, waiver of subrogation, or primary/non-contributory endorsements? Is standalone professional liability required? Is umbrella coverage acceptable? Are higher final limits expected?

Response: The minimum limits stated in RFP §4 (\$1M per occurrence / \$2M aggregate for both Commercial General Liability and Cyber Liability/Errors & Omissions) are the limits the Organization expects to require in the final agreement. The Organization will require additional insured status on the respondent's CGL policy. Errors & Omissions coverage within a combined cyber/tech E&O policy is acceptable, and standalone professional liability coverage is not separately required. Umbrella or excess coverage may be used to reach the required aggregate limits. Other endorsements, such as waiver of subrogation, will be addressed during contracting.

4.4 Records retention and audit support

What retention and format apply to MSP-held records (tickets, logs, configuration backups)? What happens at contract end? Will the MSP need to support audits (Single Audit, HUD monitoring, HIPAA assessments, cyber insurance underwriting), and is that in base scope?

Response: Records relating to this engagement are subject to the records retention and access provisions of 2 CFR 200 (RFP §10; Addendum 1 §1.4). They must be retained for at least three years from the Organization's submission of the final expenditure report for the funding award, or longer if an audit or litigation is pending (2 CFR 200.334). They must be made available to the Organization, its federal awarding agencies, pass-through entities, and their auditors. At contract end, MSP-held records are to be delivered to the Organization with the §3.1 transition deliverables. The MSP may then retain copies only as needed to meet the retention requirement, and must securely destroy them afterward. Reasonable audit and monitoring support (evidence production and written responses) is expected within base scope, up to four (4) hours per year. Support beyond that amount is billed at the respondent's rate card. Standard service reports (see 12.8) and written incident reports (§3.3) do not count against this allowance. Respondents should state any limits on their ability to retain or furnish records, or to provide audit and monitoring support, as described above.

5. Pricing & Cost Evaluation

5.1 How cost is scored

Is TCO scored strictly against the lowest figure, or weighed with other criteria?

Response: Both. Per RFP §7, the cost factor (25%) is scored by formula: the lowest responsive TCO receives maximum points, and each other proposal receives points proportional to the ratio of the lowest TCO to its own. That score is then weighted and combined with the other five factors. A

proposal scoring below 70/100 on Technical or Cybersecurity is non-responsive regardless of total. Award goes to the proposal that is “most advantageous, price and other factors considered.”

5.2 Standalone hourly rate for supplemental coverage

A respondent prices all engagements as a monthly rate and does not offer a standalone hourly rate. Does that disqualify it?

Response: RFP §3.2 and §6 require supplemental coverage priced both (a) as an annual retainer for a 160-hour pool and (b) as a standalone hourly rate, including the same-day activation rate. §6 states that respondents “must not omit a required element; an incomplete pricing submission may be found non-responsive.” A standalone rate is also needed to price hours beyond the pool and unplanned same-day activations. Respondents may otherwise present their base services as a monthly rate.

5.3 Supplemental coverage in the TCO; same-day activations

(a) Is the 160-hour volume included in each of the three years (480 hours)? (b) Do unplanned same-day activations draw down the retainer pool or bill separately?

Response: (a) Yes. The TCO includes supplemental coverage “at the volumes stated in Section 3.2” for each contract year, priced on whichever basis (retainer or hourly) gives the lower annual cost under the respondent’s proposal (§6). (b) Unplanned same-day activations are excluded from the TCO and evaluated on the stated same-day rate (§6). Unless the respondent’s proposal states otherwise, they are billed at the same-day rate and do not draw down the 160-hour planned pool. Respondents who would let same-day hours draw from the pool should say so; that will be considered favorably under the Technical factor.

5.4 Escalators and pass-throughs in the TCO

Should the TCO apply the proposed escalator in Years 2–3 or hold Year-1 pricing flat? Should pass-through license costs be held flat? Is there a preferred maximum escalator or limit on pass-through increases?

Response: Apply the respondent’s own proposed annual escalator (or cap, at its maximum) in Years 2 and 3. The TCO must be “itemized by contract year” and include “all recurring fees” (§6). Hold pass-through license costs at current published pricing across all three years, and state that assumption. Pass-through increases after award are governed by the escalator and pass-through terms each respondent must state under §6. The Organization does not set a maximum escalator; escalators are evaluated through their effect on the TCO. Third-party license increases should be passed through at cost, with documentation from the licensor and at least 60 days’ written notice.

5.5 Texas sales tax

Does Family Eldercare hold a Texas sales and use tax exemption? Should pricing exclude sales tax?

Response: State all pricing **exclusive of Texas sales and use tax**, and identify which line items the respondent considers taxable. Family Eldercare holds a Texas sales and use tax exemption and will furnish an exemption certificate (Form 01-339) at contract execution. Cost proposals will be compared on a pre-tax basis.

5.6 Optional scope shifts (§3.5) in the TCO

Are optional line items for shifting retained functions into MSP scope included in the scored TCO?

Response: No. Optional line items under the last paragraph of §3.5 must be “priced as a separate, clearly identified line item.” They are **excluded** from the TCO used for cost scoring, so respondents are not penalized for proposing them. They may be considered under the Technical factor and during negotiation.

5.7 Project work in the TCO

Please confirm that §3.4 project work (SharePoint migration, Intune deployment, hardware refresh) is excluded from the TCO.

Response: Confirmed. Project work is outside base scope and “may be quoted separately by the MSP solely at the Organization’s request” (§3.4). It is excluded from the TCO. Proposals must still state project hourly rates by engineer level (§3.4, §6 Rate Card). Unsolicited project quotes will not be scored under the cost factor.

5.8 Tier 3 block hours: comparability

Will Family Eldercare set a common assumed Tier 3 volume for pricing? Is there a target number of hours?

Response: The monthly block-hour allotment included in the base fee is left to each respondent’s judgment (§3.1, §6). For comparability, however, the Total Three-Year Cost of Ownership must price an assumed Tier 3 usage of four (4) hours per month in each contract year. Hours within the respondent’s included allotment are priced in the base fee; any hours beyond it are priced at the respondent’s stated overage rate. This assumption is for cost evaluation only and is not a commitment of volume. The allotment and rollover terms offered are also evaluated under the Technical factor. For reference, historical escalation volume is provided in 7.1.

5.9 Unlimited support

Is Family Eldercare open to an unlimited-ticket offering?

Response: Yes, respondents may propose unlimited or all-inclusive support. The proposal must still include every §6 element. Where Tier 3 hours are unlimited, state that as the allotment and disclose any fair-use limits, exclusions, or conditions that would trigger overage or project billing.

5.10 Replacement firewall and BDR ownership model

Is there a preference among outright purchase, HaaS, or amortized cost? Is capital budget available? Should alternates be priced? Does FEC expect to own the equipment at end of term?

Response: RFP §3.1 permits “purchased hardware, HaaS, or an equivalent model.” Respondents should price their recommended model in the Total Three-Year Cost of Ownership and may include one alternate model as an optional line item (see 1.5). The Organization prefers that title to the replacement firewall and BDR equipment rest with the Organization by the end of the term, whether through purchase or through HaaS with title transfer or a stated buyout. Whatever the model, proposals must state who owns the equipment during and after the term, and what happens to the equipment and its configuration if the agreement ends early (see 10.1).

5.11 Firewall and VPN changeover as a project

Can the firewall and VPN changeover be treated as a project with separate costs?

Response: The replacement firewall, remote-access VPN, and BDR provisioning are **required elements** of every proposal (§3.1). They are priced under “Provisioning, Hardware, and Travel” and “One-Time and Onboarding Costs” (§6) and **included in the TCO**. They are not §3.4 project work. Respondents may present the cutover as a discrete, itemized one-time cost, or amortize it with the schedule stated (§1, §6).

5.12 Travel to scattered sites

Is travel to the eight scattered sites included, or may it be quoted separately? Is routine on-site work at the main office and residential communities included in the base fee?

Response: §6 requires respondents to state any travel fees. Respondents may include travel in the base fee or quote it separately. If quoted separately, state the basis (per trip, per mile, or per site zone) and include an estimate in the TCO based on four (4) scattered-site visits per year. Routine on-site work is “scheduled as needed; no standing on-site cadence is required” (§3.3). Proposals should state whether on-site labor at the main office, Pecan Gardens, and Lyons Gardens falls within the base fee or Tier 3 block hours, or is billed at the rate card.

5.13 Budget or current spend

Can Family Eldercare share current annual spend or a budget range?

Response: The Organization will not publish its current contract value or a budget range. Cost is scored by formula relative to the lowest responsive proposal (§7). Respondents should propose the scope and service levels they believe best meet the requirements in §3.

5.14 HUD cost allocation

(a) What allocation methodology is required for the Lyons Gardens network administration line item? (b) The Veer and The Hedge are also HUD PSH sites. Should they be isolated too?

Response: (a) The Organization does not currently prescribe a method. Respondents should propose and state the methodology used to isolate Lyons Gardens network administration costs. Examples: the share of managed network devices located at Lyons Gardens (per Appendix A §A.4, 1 firewall, 3 switches, and 21 access points), a direct per-site charge, or another reasonable basis. The method must be documented and consistently applied so allocated costs stay auditable (Addendum 1 §1.4). Subcontracted components must be identified separately. (b) Lyons Gardens only. At The Veer and The Hedge, connectivity is provided by Google Fiber and no FEC-managed network infrastructure is present (Appendix A §A.1, §A.4). There are therefore no network administration costs to isolate there.

5.15 User and device counts; growth

How many M365 licenses are assigned? Should the ~15 miscellaneous, shared, and spare PCs count as managed devices? Do volunteers or residential staff hold accounts? What growth should be assumed? What are the exact endpoint, mailbox, and user counts for EDR and email security licensing?

Response: Price on **110 users** and **120 workstations**, which includes the miscellaneous, shared-use, and spare PCs (Appendix A §A.2). Microsoft 365 Business Premium licenses assigned: 104. Microsoft 365 Business Basic licenses assigned: approximately 20, held by a small number of volunteers and by shared, service, and administrative accounts. User mailboxes: approximately 112, of which approximately 100 are active. Shared mailboxes: approximately 575. Approximately 337 are client-specific addresses for the Organization's Guardianship program, configured as individual shared mailboxes that forward to a central program mailbox; the remainder, approximately 240, are functional and retained former-staff mailboxes. The client-specific forwarding mailboxes are excluded from Microsoft 365 backup scope; the central program mailbox is included (see 7.12). Respondents should state how their backup licensing treats shared mailboxes. Volunteers hold a small number of Organization accounts (currently three). Assume no material change in headcount, device count, or number of sites over the term. Per §6, proposals must state the per-user or per-device rate that applies if counts change.

5.16 Federal funding share

What percentage of the contract is federally funded?

Response: The federal share varies by funding source and year. The applicable 2 CFR 200 requirements (RFP §10; Addendum 1 §1.4) apply to the entire engagement regardless of share, so respondents should assume full applicability.

5.17 Hardware markup and pass-through transparency

Are there expectations or restrictions on hardware markup, shipping, travel, on-site labor, licensing pass-through, and third-party cost transparency?

Response: Proposals must state hardware markup, travel fees, and on-site labor rates (§6, Provisioning, Hardware, and Travel; Rate Card). In addition, every hardware, software, or licensing purchase made on the Organization's behalf during the term must be quoted at a fixed, itemized price, including shipping, and approved in writing by the IT & Data Manager before order. Pass-through licensing must be itemized by product and quantity on invoices. The Organization reserves the right to procure hardware and licensing directly from any source. The stated markup percentage will be used to evaluate pricing transparency and as a ceiling for purchase quotes, not as a billing basis.

6. Scope Boundaries

6.1 Strategic initiatives: base scope vs. project

§3.1 places “support for planned initiatives (Entra ID maturation, SSPR, Intune evaluation)” in base scope, while §3.4 treats Intune deployment as project work. Where is the line? How does it apply to SharePoint migration completion, password management, and workstation and mobile device management?

Response: Base scope (§3.1) covers advisory, assessment, design, and planning for these initiatives, plus ongoing administration once they are in production. That includes evaluating Intune, recommending a configuration and rollout plan, and piloting on a limited number of devices (up to 5). Fleet-wide Intune deployment, device enrollment, and migration of Group Policy to Intune are §3.4 project work. SSPR enablement, including remediation of password writeback, is base scope. The same principle applies to the other Appendix A §A.8 initiatives: advisory and planning support is base scope under §3.1 Strategic IT Guidance, while implementation is §3.4 project work priced at the Organization's request. That includes completing the SharePoint migration (see 6.5) and fleet-wide workstation or mobile device enrollment. A staff password manager may instead be proposed as an optional line item (see 6.10).

6.2 Resident vs. staff network troubleshooting

At Pecan Gardens and Lyons Gardens, who owns troubleshooting when an issue can't be cleanly isolated to the resident side or the staff side?

Response: The MSP. Per §3.1, MSP responsibility at both residential communities “extends to the resident and guest network infrastructure and its segmentation from staff VLANs.” Diagnosing issues in shared or segmented network infrastructure is therefore MSP scope on either side. Only “individual end-user support for residents, visitors, and volunteers” (for example, a resident’s personal device) is out of scope. In practice, the MSP owns uptime, capacity, and segmentation of the resident and guest networks, and investigates when a pattern of resident connectivity problems points to the infrastructure (for example, an access point, VLAN, or DHCP issue). A single resident’s or visitor’s device that can’t connect while the network is otherwise working normally is out of scope.

6.3 Scattered-site equipment and printers

Is any network equipment at the eight scattered sites Organization-owned or MSP-managed, including the AT&T fixed wireless units? Can printer counts at the “to be confirmed” sites be provided, and is network print configuration MSP or retained scope?

Response: At the scattered sites, connectivity is property- or carrier-provided (Appendix A §A.1, §A.4), including the AT&T FWA units at Gaston Place and Pathways at North Loop. No FEC-owned network infrastructure there is in MSP scope. MSP scope at those sites is limited to the Organization’s endpoints (security, patching, and management tooling) and their remote-access connectivity. Printers and managed print are retained by the Organization (§3.5) and outside MSP base scope, except for first-line coordination during §3.2 coverage periods. Printer inventory at the listed sites therefore does not affect base pricing; respondents do not need to price managed print.

6.4 EOL Cisco SG300 switches

Is replacement of the two SG300 switches base scope, a priced project, or scheduled before cutover?

Response: The Organization plans to remove the two SG300 switches in October 2026, before the onboarding period begins. Respondents should not price their replacement or ongoing management. If removal is not complete by contract start, any remaining removal, re-cabling, or reconfiguration would be §3.4 project work quoted at the Organization’s request, and the switches would be monitored and maintained under §3.1 on a best-effort basis until removed, given their end-of-life status.

6.5 SharePoint migration and legacy file server

Will the SharePoint migration finish before Feb 1? Should the incoming MSP support the Windows Server 2012 R2 file server during onboarding or after?

Response: The SharePoint migration is ongoing and may not be complete by the February 1, 2027 contract start. Respondents should assume the file server VM is in production at contract start and remains so for part of Year 1. It will be decommissioned when the migration is complete (Appendix A §A.3). Until then, the MSP should plan to include the file server VM in backup and DR (§3.1) and in monitoring, and the replacement BDR solution must protect it from cutover. Windows Server 2012 R2 is past Microsoft end of support, so maintenance is best-effort, with compensating controls as the MSP recommends. Any remaining migration or decommissioning tasks at contract start would be §3.4 project work.

6.6 Long-term identity direction

Is there a plan or preference to move to cloud-only / Entra-joined identity during the term, or will on-prem AD persist?

Response: There is no committed plan. The Organization expects to evaluate its identity direction with the MSP as part of the twice-yearly strategic technology reviews (§3.1), informed by the Intune evaluation and file server decommission. Respondents should assume the on-premises domain controller persists for pricing, and may describe their recommended path.

6.7 Network standardization and internet failover

Are there plans to consolidate satellite networking onto Ubiquiti or a single platform? Would FEC like to see optional line items for standardization and internet failover? Is failover in place anywhere today?

Response: There is no current plan to consolidate platforms. Respondents may propose standardization and/or internet redundancy as clearly separated optional line items (§3.5) or as indicative project pricing (§3.4). These are excluded from the scored TCO (see 5.6, 5.7). Internet failover is currently in place at the main office only, where a Cradlepoint S700 cellular router on AT&T Internet Air for Business provides a secondary connection. The replacement main-office firewall (§3.1) must support this connection as a failover WAN, and the Transition Plan should address its cutover. No failover is in place at Pecan Gardens, Lyons Gardens, or the scattered sites.

6.8 BitLocker state

Are all workstations BitLocker-encrypted with keys escrowed, and to Entra ID or on-prem AD? Is remediation of non-compliant devices base scope?

Response: Recovery keys are escrowed to on-premises Active Directory (workstations are AD-joined only; see 7.5). Current state: of the 104 workstations active in the last 60 days, 96 have recovery keys escrowed and 8 do not; the remaining workstations are spare or shared-use devices not used during that period. Remediation of non-compliant devices is **base scope**. §3.1 requires the MSP to “verify and maintain BitLocker full-disk encryption on all Organization workstations, with recovery keys escrowed and accessible to the Organization.” Where hands-on work is needed, the IT & Data Manager may perform the physical touch in coordination with the MSP.

6.9 Security awareness training

Who provides the program started in June 2026? Is it licensed through the incumbent? Should respondents include a replacement?

Response: The current program is licensed through the current provider and will not transfer at contract end. Respondents should include a replacement security awareness training and phishing simulation program as a separate cost component, priced on its own line in Attachment A Part A and not included in the monthly base fee.

6.10 Password management and credential repository

Is the “password management solution” in Appendix A §A.8 an end-user password manager, the §3.1 administrative credential repository, or both? Base fee or option? Is the credential repository owned by the Organization, or provided by the MSP?

Response: Appendix A §A.8 refers to an **end-user password manager for all staff**. Respondents may propose one as an optional line item; like other optional line items, it is excluded from the Total Three-Year Cost of Ownership used for cost scoring (see 5.6). The administrative credential repository required by §3.1 is maintained by the Organization (§3.5). The MSP must document all administrative credentials in it, but is not expected to provide it. If a respondent proposes a solution that also serves as the credential repository, the Organization must own the tenant or vault and retain sole ownership of its contents at end of term (§3.1).

6.11 Zero-trust access instead of a client VPN

Would an identity-based zero-trust network access (ZTNA) service satisfy the requirement for “an equivalent remote-access VPN for staff,” or must it be a traditional client VPN on the firewall?

Response: A ZTNA service satisfies §3.1 if all of the following hold: it gives staff equivalent or better access to on-premises resources; it is included in the base fee or itemized; and its licensing

and end-of-term transition are stated per §5. The Transition Plan must still address client migration on all affected workstations (§3.1).

6.12 SIEM

Is SIEM service expected or required as part of the in-scope security monitoring and response?

Response: A SIEM product is not required by name. §3.1 requires security monitoring and incident response, and §3.3 treats credential compromise and business email compromise as Critical Issues. Proposals must therefore describe how the respondent monitors, at a minimum, endpoint (EDR/XDR) telemetry, Microsoft 365 and Entra ID sign-in and audit activity, email security events, and firewall logs, and how alerts from those sources are correlated, triaged, and retained. Respondents may meet this through a SIEM, an MDR/XDR service, or equivalent tooling, and should state log retention and whether the service is included in the base fee. This is evaluated under the Cybersecurity factor.

6.13 Spare equipment inventory

Is the MSP expected to maintain inventory or stock of spare mobile devices, workstations, peripherals, or network gear?

Response: No. Endpoint procurement and asset lifecycle, including spare workstations, mobile devices, and peripherals, are retained by the Organization (§3.5; Appendix A §A.2). The MSP is not expected to stock network spares. Respondents may recommend a spares strategy for critical network components (for example, a cold-spare switch or access point) as part of strategic guidance, and should state advance-replacement or hardware-support terms for any equipment they provide under §3.1, such as the replacement firewall and BDR.

7. Environment & Sizing Data

7.1 Historical support volume

Can FEC share, for the last 12 months, by technology type and severity: monthly ticket volume across all tiers; Tier 3 escalation hours or tickets; Critical and High-priority issues; after-hours incidents; on-site dispatches by site; and downtime and its sources?

Response: Approximate trailing-12-month figures:

- Internal Tier 1/Tier 2 tickets: approximately 50 per month (approximately 2–3 per business day)
- Escalations to the current MSP: approximately 4 tickets per month. Under the current arrangement these include Tier 1/Tier 2 issues that will be retained by the Organization under the co-managed model (§3.5), so this figure overstates expected Tier 3 volume. The Critical and High-priority figures below are the better guide to Tier 3 demand.

- Critical-class incidents (as defined in §3.3): 2, both involving email and identity security; compensating controls have since been strengthened
- High-priority incidents: 4 (loss of access to network file shares following a network device change; print server issues; a Microsoft-side OneDrive sharing issue; and a workstation operating system fault)
- After-hours incidents: 1 (one of the two Critical incidents)
- On-site dispatches: Main Office 2, both for project work; Pecan Gardens, Lyons Gardens, and scattered sites 0
- Notable unplanned downtime: three internet service outages of approximately 1–4 hours each at the main office, and one power loss of approximately 4 hours

These figures are approximate, provided for sizing only, and are not a guarantee of future volume.

7.2 Backup sizing

What is the incumbent BDR appliance's storage capacity? How much on-prem VM storage is in use? What are total M365 data volumes (Exchange, SharePoint, OneDrive, Teams) and annual growth?

Response:

- Host storage (Appendix A §A.3): 2×480 GB SSD in RAID 1 (≈480 GB usable) plus 6×1.2 TB SAS in RAID 5 (≈6.0 TB usable)
- Used capacity: domain controller VM approximately 71 GB used of 250 GB provisioned; file server VM approximately 2.7 TB used of 3.0 TB provisioned across three volumes (expected to decline as the SharePoint migration completes)
- Current BDR appliance: approximately 6 TB of replication capacity. The appliance will be returned, so respondents should size the replacement to the protected data, not to the current appliance.
- Microsoft 365: Exchange Online approximately 1.3 TB in user mailboxes and approximately 1.4 TB in shared mailboxes (mailbox counts in 5.15; scope in 7.12); SharePoint approximately 1.4 TB; OneDrive approximately 1.1 TB. Teams data is stored within Exchange, SharePoint, and OneDrive and is included in those figures.
- Estimated annual growth: Exchange approximately 5% annually; SharePoint and OneDrive approximately 10–20% annually, partly reflecting the ongoing SharePoint migration (estimated from 180-day usage reporting).

7.3 Retention requirements

What retention periods should be assumed for M365 backup, on-prem VM backup, and quarterly LOB exports? Do 2 CFR 200.334, HIPAA, HUD, legal, or internal retention policies set minimums?

Response: For comparability, respondents should price the following minimum retention:

- On-premises VMs: daily backups retained for 30 days, plus monthly backups retained for 12 months
- Microsoft 365: 3 years
- Quarterly LOB exports: retain the most recent 12 quarterly exports (3 years)

Respondents may propose longer retention as an option. Where federal award records are involved, the 2 CFR 200.334 three-year minimum applies (see 4.4).

7.4 Ticketing, RMM, and case transfer

What ticketing system does the IT & Data Manager use? Will the MSP's ticketing, RMM, and remote-access platforms be used, or must the MSP work inside or integrate with FEC's systems? How are tickets transferred between the Organization and the MSP?

Response: The Organization does not use a dedicated ITSM platform. Internal Tier 1/Tier 2 tickets are submitted through a Microsoft Forms intake that feeds a SharePoint list. Tickets escalated to the MSP will be entered as new tickets in the MSP's ticketing platform, which will be the system of record for escalations and for tickets received during §3.2 coverage periods. Per §5, the IT & Data Manager must be granted standing access to the MSP's ticketing platform, with at least read access to all of the Organization's tickets. Integration or ticket mirroring with the Organization's system is not required. Where it would simplify escalations and coverage, the Organization is willing to log internal Tier 1/Tier 2 tickets directly in the MSP's ticketing platform, provided this is offered at no additional cost and the Organization's ticket history is exportable at contract end (see 10.4); respondents offering this should say so. The MSP's RMM and remote-access platforms will be used for managed endpoints and infrastructure, with standing access for the IT & Data Manager (§5; see 12.5). The Organization will not retain its own remote-support tool; the IT & Data Manager will use the MSP's remote-access tooling under that standing access. For case transfer: escalations to the MSP should carry the Organization's triage notes and ticket reference, and tickets returned to the Organization should include resolution notes, so history stays continuous across both systems. Respondents should describe their co-managed case-transfer process, including how ticket ownership is shown at each stage; this is evaluated under the Nonprofit and co-managed experience factor.

7.5 Identity configuration

Is directory sync Entra Connect or Cloud Sync? Is password writeback enabled? Are devices hybrid-joined?

Response: Directory synchronization uses Entra Connect Sync, with password hash synchronization and seamless single sign-on. Password writeback is not fully configured; its remediation is included in base scope (see 6.1). Workstations are joined to on-premises Active Directory only, not hybrid Entra-joined. Entra ID is used for Microsoft 365 applications only, with no third-party SSO integrations (Appendix A §A.5).

7.6 Network licensing and admin

What are the license status and expiry dates for the Meraki gear at Lyons Gardens and the SonicWall at Pecan Gardens? Who holds Meraki dashboard org admin?

Response: Meraki (Lyons Gardens) licensing: co-termination (MX Advanced Security, MR Enterprise), covering 1 MX84, 3 MS225-24P switches, and 21 MR access points, expiring August 21, 2028. SonicWall (Pecan Gardens) security services: expiry to be confirmed during onboarding. Meraki dashboard organization admin is held by the Organization. License renewals falling within the term are Organization costs unless a respondent proposes otherwise.

7.7 Remote access and IP dependencies

How many workstations have Sophos Connect installed, and how many staff use it regularly? Are there site-to-site VPNs or IP allow-lists tied to the main office (Bonterra, MIP, Nextiva)? Can the replacement client be deployed remotely?

Response: Sophos Connect is installed on all end-user workstations, and approximately 14 staff use it regularly. Beyond regular remote access, remote staff rely on the VPN to reach the on-premises domain controller for password changes, so the replacement remote-access solution (including any ZTNA approach under 6.11) must preserve that capability until SSPR with password writeback is in place (see 6.1). There are no site-to-site VPNs, and no known IP allow-lists tied to the main-office public IP. All workstations are managed remotely through the MSP's tooling. Respondents should plan for remote deployment of the replacement client, with per-device physical touch limited to exceptions. The IT & Data Manager can assist with hands-on exceptions.

7.8 Microsoft 365 licensing channel

Are M365 licenses purchased directly, through the incumbent as CSP, or through a reseller? Should license costs appear in the proposal?

Response: Microsoft 365 licenses are purchased directly from Microsoft. No change is anticipated, and M365 license costs should not be included in proposals.

7.9 Resident and guest networks

How many resident units or ports do the resident and guest networks at Pecan Gardens and Lyons Gardens serve? Are they subject to HUD or funder conditions (content filtering, acceptable use, reporting)?

Response: Pecan Gardens serves approximately 78 resident units; Lyons Gardens approximately 53. Wireless infrastructure is listed in Appendix A §A.4. No HUD or funder conditions currently require content filtering or connectivity reporting on the resident networks.

7.10 LOB export mechanics

Do Apricot Core and MIP Cloud support scheduled or API exports at FEC’s license tier? What size and format are they? Where should they be stored? Must restorability be validated, and do vendor terms permit test restores?

Response: Apricot Core exports are provided as a SQL database dump of approximately 110 GB; export mechanics will be confirmed with the selected respondent during onboarding. MIP Cloud does not support full data exports under the Organization’s subscription. In their place, the MIP Cloud portion of the line-of-business export data class in RFP §3.1 consists of the Organization’s periodic MIP transaction record exports, approximately 100 GB cumulative and growing by approximately 5 GB per year. These records are currently stored on the Organization’s file server, so they are also protected by on-premises VM backup until the file server is decommissioned (see 6.5). Because these records are cumulative, respondents may propose incremental capture rather than full quarterly copies. Exports should be stored in the respondent’s backup repository, subject to the U.S.-region storage requirement in 3.2, and retained per 7.3 (the most recent 12 quarterly exports, approximately 2.5 TB at current size: about 1.3 TB of Apricot Core exports and 1.2 TB of MIP transaction records if captured as full copies). Per Appendix A §A.8, annual DR testing includes “validation of the most recent quarterly LOB exports,” meaning the exports must be confirmed complete and readable. Full restore into a vendor test environment is not required.

7.11 Organization holidays

Will the observed holiday schedule be published?

Response: The Organization observes 14 holiday days per year. Based on the current schedule, respondents should assume the following:

- New Year’s Day and the day after (2 days)
- Martin Luther King Jr. Day
- Presidents’ Day
- Memorial Day
- Juneteenth
- Independence Day
- Labor Day
- Indigenous Peoples’ Day
- Veterans Day
- Thanksgiving Day and the day after (2 days)
- Christmas Eve and Christmas Day (2 days)

The final 2027 schedule, including observed dates, will be issued during the onboarding period. Critical Issue obligations under §3.3 apply on holidays.

7.12 Microsoft 365 backup scope

Should M365 backup cover all licensed users and all Exchange, SharePoint, OneDrive, and Teams data, including inactive users and shared mailboxes, or only active users and production sites?

Response: Price backup of all Exchange Online user, shared, and resource mailboxes, excluding the client-specific Guardianship forwarding mailboxes described in 5.15 (the central program mailbox they forward to is included), all OneDrive accounts, all SharePoint sites, and Microsoft Teams data (channel conversations and files; including 1:1 and group chats), across all users. Data belonging to departed users must remain recoverable for the retention period in 7.3 after offboarding, whether or not their license is removed. Respondents should state how their licensing treats shared mailboxes and departed users, since that drives cost.

7.13 Disaster recovery testing and restore verification

Are DR tests required, and how often? What should the annual restore verification include (file-level, VM, M365, full DR simulation), and what evidence is expected?

Response: Restore verification is required annually (§3.1; Appendix A §A.8). It should include:

- a full restore and boot test of each on-premises VM in the BDR solution's local virtualization, measured against the one-business-day RTO;
- select file and mailbox restores, including Microsoft 365 items (a mailbox, a OneDrive folder, a SharePoint library item) once third-party M365 backup is in place, measured against the four-business-hour RTO; and
- validation that the most recent quarterly LOB exports are complete and readable (see 7.10).

A full disaster recovery simulation is not required. Evidence should be a written test report covering what was restored, when, time to restore against the RTO, results, and any issues with remediation. The IT & Data Manager participates (Appendix B). An annual incident response tabletop exercise, facilitated by the MSP with the IT & Data Manager and Incident Notification recipients, is also included in base scope. Respondents may propose more frequent testing as an option.

8. Service Levels & Supplemental Coverage

8.1 Supplemental coverage: on-site or remote, blocks or hourly, full or overflow?

During §3.2 coverage periods, is a technician expected on-site at the main office, or is remote coverage acceptable? What daily volume should be assumed, and how are the ~20 planned days distributed? Should vendors assume full-day blocks, partial days, or flexible hourly usage? Does the MSP provide full end-user support, or overflow alongside FEC staff?

Response: §3.2 does not require a technician on-site for the duration of coverage periods. Remote first-line coverage is expected and acceptable. On-site response should be available as needed at

the rates or terms stated in the proposal, consistent with the On-site Capability requirement (§4). Respondents should assume approximately 3–5 end-user tickets per coverage day. This is deliberately above the Organization’s typical internal volume (see 7.1) so that respondents can size coverage staffing to meet the Organization’s needs. Planned coverage days are typically scheduled as single days or one-week blocks, usually with about one month’s advance notice; the 24–48 hours’ notice in §3.2 remains the minimum. For pricing, assume planned coverage is used in full business-day blocks (9:00 AM–5:00 PM); partial-day activations may occur and draw down the pool in the respondent’s stated minimum billing increment. During coverage periods, the MSP provides full first-line (Tier 1/Tier 2) support directly to all Organization users. This is not overflow support: the IT & Data Manager is the Organization’s only internal IT staff, so no internal staff will be working alongside the MSP.

8.2 Coverage intake and vendor authorization

During coverage periods, how do staff reach the MSP? Will the MSP be pre-authorized with Nextiva, ISP, wireless, and print vendors?

Response: During coverage periods, staff will be directed to the MSP’s published intake channels (phone, email, and/or portal). The Organization will direct staff to those channels for the duration of each coverage period. During onboarding, the Organization will add the MSP as an authorized contact on the Nextiva, internet service, AT&T wireless, and managed print accounts, so that §3.2 first-line coordination can begin on the first day of any coverage period.

8.3 When the Incident Notification clock starts

Does an unverified alert from the MSP’s monitoring start the 4-hour clock, or only once an analyst triages it as a reasonably suspected incident?

Response: An automated alert that on triage proves to be a false positive is not a Critical Issue and triggers no Incident Notification. Where triage determines that an alert reflects a confirmed or reasonably suspected security incident, Discovery occurs at the time the MSP’s tooling generated the alert, not when triage finished. §3.3 defines Discovery to include “the MSP’s own detection of an issue through monitoring, tooling, or staff observation.” Timely triage is therefore part of meeting the 4-hour requirement. Respondents should state their alert triage time commitments.

8.4 On-site “by end of next business day”: when does it start? Weekends?

Does the clock start at Discovery or once remote resolution is confirmed impossible? For a Critical Issue discovered Friday evening or on the weekend, does Monday attendance satisfy it? Do the residential communities have overnight or weekend staffing?

Response: On-site response is due by the end of the next business day after the MSP determines, or should reasonably have determined, that the Critical Issue cannot be resolved remotely. That determination must be made promptly and communicated in the Incident Notification or its

updates. For an issue discovered after business hours on a Friday or weekend, attendance by end of business Monday (or the next business day, if Monday is a holiday) meets the §3.3 **minimum**. Respondents offering faster or weekend on-site response should say so; it will be considered under the Technical factor. Pecan Gardens and Lyons Gardens do not have overnight or weekend Organization staff, and residents live on-site at both. After-hours site access is arranged through the IT & Data Manager (§3.5).

8.5 Same-day unplanned activation

What start-of-service timeframe should vendors assume, and does coverage continue for the rest of the business day once activated?

Response: §3.2 asks respondents to state how quickly same-day coverage can begin; that commitment is evaluated under the Technical factor. For pricing and staffing, assume same-day requests are made by 9:00 AM and that coverage continues through the end of that business day once activated, unless the Organization ends it earlier. Respondents should state the minimum billing for a same-day activation.

8.6 24x7 monitoring vs. on-call

Is continuous 24x7 monitoring and incident response required in base scope, or is an on-call model acceptable if it meets the §3.3 Critical Issue requirements?

Response: A staffed 24x7 SOC is not required. §3.3 does require Incident Notification within four hours of Discovery “at any hour” for Critical Issues, and continuous work until Resolved, and Discovery includes detection by the MSP’s own tooling (see 8.3). Automated monitoring and alerting must therefore run 24x7. An on-call model is acceptable if it can triage after-hours alerts and deliver Incident Notification within that window. Respondents should describe after-hours alert routing, on-call staffing, and triage times, and state whether a 24x7 SOC or MDR service is included; that will be considered under the Cybersecurity factor.

8.7 Resolution-time targets

§3.3 asks respondents to propose target Resolution times. Are there minimum or preferred targets?

Response: No minimums are set. For reference, the Organization’s preferred targets are: Critical, continuous work until Resolved; High-priority, 1 business day; Standard, 3 business days; Routine, 5 business days or as scheduled. Respondents may propose different targets and should explain why.

8.8 After-hours billing boundary

Should after-hours support be included in the base fee for defined severities, drawn against Tier 3 block hours, or billed separately by rate card?

Response: §3.3 and §6 require each respondent to state whether after-hours coverage is included in the base fee or billed as a surcharge, with rates. The Organization prefers that after-hours response to Critical Issues be included in the base fee. Other after-hours work requested by the Organization may be drawn from block hours or billed at the rate card, as the respondent proposes. Proposals should state which treatment applies to each issue class.

9. Transition & Onboarding

9.1 Incumbent awareness and cooperation

Is the incumbent aware of the re-bid? Is it obligated to cooperate with transition (documentation, credentials, knowledge transfer)? Should respondents plan for a non-cooperative handoff? Will FEC facilitate a knowledge-transfer session?

Response: This is a public solicitation. The Organization will coordinate the transition with the current provider under the terms of the existing agreement, and anticipates facilitating a knowledge-transfer session during the onboarding period. The Organization also anticipates that administrative credentials, and such environment documentation as the current provider furnishes, will be transferred during the onboarding period to assist discovery. The Organization retains ownership of its tenant, domains, and configurations. Respondents should nonetheless plan a Transition Plan that does not depend on any particular level of incumbent cooperation. It should identify what the respondent will rebuild from discovery, and should address credential and administrative-access handoff as required by §5.

9.2 Parallel run of firewall and BDR

Will FEC allow the replacement firewall and BDR to be installed and run in parallel during Dec 7–Jan 31 before the incumbent’s equipment is removed? What is the removal date?

Response: Yes. The Organization anticipates that the replacement firewall and BDR solution may be staged, installed, and run in parallel during the onboarding period (Dec 7, 2026 – Jan 31, 2027), subject to change authorization by the IT & Data Manager (§3.5) and coordination with the current provider. The incumbent’s equipment will be removed at cutover, which must be complete before February 1, 2027.

9.3 Configuration and documentation at award

Will the selected vendor receive the existing firewall configuration and network documentation at contract execution, or should respondents plan to rebuild from discovery? Will network diagrams,

IP schema, and an asset register be available on award, before Dec 7? Will an updated infrastructure inventory be provided?

Response: After contract execution, the Organization will provide its internal environment documentation, which is partially outdated, plus its asset inventory and whatever configuration exports it can obtain. Respondents should price onboarding on the assumption that firewall rule bases, NAT, and VPN configuration are **rebuilt from discovery** during the onboarding period. Any configuration exports received will reduce that effort, but should not be relied on. The Organization will also provide an updated inventory of network, firewall, wireless, server, and other shared infrastructure by the start of the onboarding period, completing the items marked “to be confirmed” in Appendix A. Printers remain Organization-retained scope (see 6.3).

9.4 Onboarding-period access and parallel tool deployment

Will the selected vendor receive administrative and read-only access at the start of onboarding, with rights to deploy RMM, EDR/XDR, email security, remote access, and backup agents before Feb 1? Can replacement EDR and email security run in parallel with SentinelOne and Avanan?

Response: Yes. The selected vendor will be granted access at the start of the onboarding period, following contract execution (§5, §8), and may deploy its tooling before February 1, 2027, subject to the IT & Data Manager’s change authorization (§3.5) and coordination with the current provider. Parallel operation with the incumbent-licensed SentinelOne and Avanan is permitted where technically compatible. The Transition Plan should describe the respondent’s coexistence and cutover approach, including how it avoids conflicts between concurrent EDR agents.

9.5 Firewall and VPN swap timeline

How long will the respondent have to swap the firewall and set up VPN?

Response: The onboarding period runs **December 7, 2026 – January 31, 2027** (§8). Firewall, VPN, and BDR cutover must be complete by the February 1, 2027 contract start. §7 assesses the Transition factor partly on “demonstrated ability to complete onboarding within the window stated in the Section 8 timeline.”

9.6 What transfers from the current environment

Which current tools, licenses, appliances, and configurations transfer to the selected MSP, and which are replaced at cutover (SentinelOne, Avanan, Sophos firewall/VPN configuration, BDR appliance and data, documentation, backup history)?

Response:

- **Replaced at cutover:** SentinelOne and Avanan licensing (Appendix A §A.5); other security tooling licensed through the current provider, including XDR, SaaS alerting, privileged access management, and security awareness training (see 6.9); the Sophos XGS 126 firewall and its Sophos Connect VPN; and the BDR solution (§3.1). Respondents must price replacements.

- **Organization-owned and retained:** the Microsoft 365 tenant, domains, Microsoft 365 licensing (see 7.8), and network equipment at Pecan Gardens and Lyons Gardens (§3.1; Appendix A §A.4).
- **Configurations:** Plan to rebuild the main-office firewall rule base, NAT, and VPN from discovery (see 9.3). Configuration exports the Organization obtains will be provided but should not be relied on.
- **Documentation:** Internal environment documentation and inventory are provided after contract execution (see 9.3).
- **Backup data and history:** Assume retention history in the current BDR solution does not transfer, and that the new backup regime starts at cutover. The selected respondent will take a final full backup of the on-premises VMs to Organization-owned storage during the onboarding period, before the current BDR solution is removed, and should include this in its onboarding costs.

10. Contract Terms

10.1 Annual-term tools and termination for convenience

Termination for convenience after Year 1 would leave the MSP holding annual-term tool commitments. Will FEC pay remaining tool costs if it terminates early? How is any unamortized balance of onboarding, firewall, BDR, backup, licensing, or transition costs handled?

Response: RFP §1 permits termination for convenience on 90 days' written notice after the first 12 months, without early-termination fee or penalty, subject only to settlement of any itemized, unamortized onboarding balance. No balance is owed on termination for cause or vendor breach. Where a respondent's tools carry non-cancelable annual commitments, the respondent may itemize those commitments in its pricing. As a clarification of RFP §1, on termination for convenience the Organization will also pay the unexpired portion of the current annual term of any non-cancelable tool commitment that was itemized in Attachment A Part B and whose license is transferred to the Organization's name at termination. Payment is based on the annual amount itemized in the proposal. No such payment is owed on termination for cause. For tools that cannot be transferred, respondents should account for that risk in their pricing. Where replacement firewall or BDR hardware is amortized into monthly fees, the same settlement treatment applies, and title to the hardware transfers to the Organization upon settlement. Per §5, proposals must state whether each tool is licensed in the respondent's or the Organization's name and how it is transitioned or terminated at the end of the engagement.

10.2 Contract documents in advance

Will FEC share its HIPAA BAA form and standard services agreement before proposals are due?

Response: The Organization's Business Associate Agreement form will be distributed to all registered respondents by October 9, 2026. The services agreement will be negotiated with the selected respondent (Nov 20 – Dec 4). Respondents should identify in their proposals any

exceptions to the terms stated in the RFP (for example §1 termination and §3.1 credential ownership). Exceptions will be considered in evaluation.

10.3 Tool transitionability at contract end

For MSP-provided tools and licenses, what level of transitionability, export, assignment, or customer ownership is expected at contract end?

Response: Per §5, proposals must state for each tool whether it is licensed in the MSP's or the Organization's name and how it transitions or terminates. At a minimum, the Organization expects: (a) backup data, including retention history, to be exportable in a usable format or the backup licensing to be transferable, and in either case retained without gap until the successor's backups are verified; (b) ticket history and documentation to be exportable (see 10.4); and (c) security tooling (EDR/XDR, email security) to remain active through an overlap period of up to 30 days after termination, at the then-current rate, so a successor can deploy without a protection gap. Tools licensed in the Organization's name remain the Organization's.

10.4 Transition-out package

What artifacts should the transition-out package include at contract end or termination, and in what export formats?

Response: Beyond the §3.1 deliverables (complete environment documentation, configuration exports, and all administrative credentials within ten business days of notice), the package should include:

- current network diagrams, IP schema, and asset inventory;
- firewall, switch, and wireless configuration exports in native format;
- backup job configuration, retention settings, and the most recent restore verification report;
- the Organization's ticket history as a CSV or equivalent export;
- the last 12 months of service and security reports;
- open issues, pending changes, and known risks; and
- records subject to 2 CFR 200 retention (see 4.4).

Documentation should be delivered in commonly readable formats (PDF, DOCX, XLSX, CSV, or native configuration files), not solely as access to the MSP's platform.

11. Incumbent & Organizational Motivations

11.1 Incumbent status

Will the incumbent bid?

Response: The Organization does not disclose the identities of registered or prospective respondents before award. The current provider may respond on the same terms as any other respondent.

11.2 Rationale for the RFP

What's driving the change, and where has the current provider fallen short?

Response: The Organization will not comment on the performance of any current provider. As stated in RFP §1, this competitive evaluation aims “to improve operational efficiency, strengthen service delivery, and reduce costs in alignment with its mission-driven goals.” Current environment challenges are listed in Appendix A §A.8.

11.3 Success criteria

What would a successful first year look like? What's the #1 problem you want solved?

Response: At the end of the first year, the Organization would consider the engagement successful if:

- the transition, including the firewall, remote access, BDR, and security tooling, was completed on schedule without disruption to client services;
- Microsoft 365 data is protected by a third-party backup with verified restores;
- escalations are resolved reliably within the §3.3 service levels, with clear communication to the IT & Data Manager;
- measurable progress has been made on the Appendix A §A.8 priorities (SSPR, Intune evaluation, documentation, and security enhancement); and
- the IT & Data Manager's absences are covered seamlessly under §3.2.

12. Co-Managed Operations & Governance

12.1 Incident Notification List and after-hours escalation

Will FEC provide a finalized Incident Notification List, escalation priority, and preferred after-hours communication procedure during onboarding?

Response: Yes. The Organization will provide its Incident Notification List (§3.3) during onboarding, with recipients in escalation order and preferred after-hours contact methods. The selected MSP and the IT & Data Manager will document the after-hours procedure together before February 1, 2027. The §3.3 requirement that every listed recipient be notified still applies; escalation order sets who is called first, not who may be left out.

12.2 MACD volume and timeframes

What MACD volumes should vendors assume, and what are expected execution timeframes for standard requests?

Response: Most end-user moves, adds, changes, and deletes (onboarding and offboarding, license assignment, permissions, equipment moves) are retained by the Organization (§3.5). MSP-side MACD is mainly infrastructure: firewall rules, VLAN and switch-port changes, wireless changes,

Group Policy, and security tooling. Volume is low: over the past 12 months there were no recurring firewall, switch-port, or wireless requests, and a small number of Group Policy changes. For pricing, assume approximately one such request per month. These are Routine Requests under §3.3 (Acknowledgment within one business day); respondents should state target completion times.

12.3 Change management

What change-management process, approvals, emergency-change procedure, documentation, CAB expectations, and monthly change volume should vendors assume?

Response: The Organization does not operate a formal CAB. Material configuration changes require prior authorization by the IT & Data Manager (§3.5), requested through the MSP's ticketing platform with a description, expected impact, schedule, and rollback plan. Pre-approved standard changes (for example, routine patching within agreed maintenance windows) will be defined during onboarding. Emergency changes without prior authorization are limited to immediate action to contain an active security incident (§3.5; see 12.4). Assume approximately one material change per month, excluding pre-approved standard changes. Respondents should describe their change-management process.

12.4 Security incident containment

For incidents requiring immediate containment, what post-action notification, approval, and documentation should the MSP follow?

Response: Where the MSP acts without prior authorization to contain an active security incident (§3.5), it must: report the action in the Incident Notification, whose required content includes "whether the MSP has taken immediate action required to contain an active security incident" (§3.3); record the action, time, and rationale in a change ticket for retroactive review by the IT & Data Manager; prefer reversible containment (isolating an endpoint, disabling an account) over destructive action; and cover the action in the written incident report due within five business days. Actions beyond immediate containment require authorization.

12.5 IT & Data Manager access in MSP tools

Beyond the standing access required by §5, is there a preferred role or level of access in MSP ticketing, RMM, remote-access, backup, documentation, and security platforms?

Response: The IT & Data Manager should have technician-level access to the MSP's RMM and remote-access tools for Organization endpoints; full visibility of the Organization's tickets; read access to backup consoles and job reports; read access to security platform dashboards and alerts; and read and export access to the Organization's documentation. Respondents should state any role limitations and the reason for them.

12.6 Supplemental help desk playbooks

Does FEC have playbooks or runbooks for supplemental coverage? If not, will FEC help create them during onboarding?

Response: The Organization does not currently have formal playbooks for coverage periods. The Organization will work with the selected MSP to create them during onboarding, covering common requests, escalation contacts, vendor accounts (see 8.2), and site-specific notes. Respondents should describe their approach to building and maintaining them.

12.7 Security and IT policies

Will FEC provide its current information security, acceptable-use, access-control, incident-response, and other IT policies during onboarding?

Response: Yes. The Organization will provide its current IT and security policies to the selected MSP during onboarding. These currently include an IT Incident Response Policy, which the Organization expects to update for the new engagement, and an AI acceptable use policy now in development. Other IT and security policies are not yet formalized. Respondents may describe policy development support as part of strategic guidance (§3.1) or as optional project work.

12.8 Reporting cadence and content

What operational and security reports are expected, at what cadence, and for which recipients?

Response: The RFP requires BitLocker compliance in regular service reporting (§3.1) and written incident reports (§3.3). At a minimum, the Organization expects a monthly report to the IT & Data Manager covering ticket volume and SLA performance by class, Tier 3 block-hour usage, patch compliance, backup job success and restore tests, security alerts and incidents, BitLocker compliance, and license and device counts, plus an executive summary for each strategic review (12.9). Respondents should describe their standard reports and cadence.

12.9 Strategic review cadence and participants

What cadence, format, and participants should vendors assume for business reviews?

Response: At least twice annually (§3.1). Assume one-to-two-hour reviews, held in person at the main office or virtually at the Organization's option, attended for the Organization by the IT & Data Manager and a member of executive leadership, and for the MSP by its account manager and a senior engineer. Reviews cover service performance, security posture, roadmap, and budget input. The Organization's fiscal year follows the calendar year, so one review each year should be held in the third quarter, ahead of the budget cycle, so that MSP input can inform the next year's IT budget.

Attachment A – Pricing Summary Form

Complete this form and place it at the front of the pricing submission (RFP §6). Respondents may reproduce the form in their own format, provided every line item below is included in the same order and with the same labels (see 1.6). Pricing forms do not count against the page limit (RFP §5). State all amounts in U.S. dollars, exclusive of Texas sales and use tax (see 5.5).

Part A – Total Three-Year Cost of Ownership

Cost component	Year 1	Year 2	Year 3	Total
Monthly base fee × 12				
Tier 3 overage at an assumed 4 hours per month, for hours beyond the included allotment (see 5.8)				
Supplemental help desk coverage, 160 hours per year, priced on the lower of retainer or hourly (§6; see 5.3)				
Microsoft 365 backup (§3.1)				
Security awareness training and phishing simulation (see 6.9)				
Replacement firewall and BDR (state model: purchase / HaaS / amortized)				
One-time and onboarding costs				
Travel, if not included in the base fee, based on four (4) scattered-site visits per year (see 5.12)				
Other recurring or one-time costs (itemize)				
Total				
Total Three-Year Cost of Ownership (scored under RFP §7)				

Instructions for Part A:

- Apply the proposed annual escalator in Years 2 and 3; hold pass-through license costs at current published pricing (see 5.4).
- Enter each cost once. Where a cost is amortized into the base fee, enter “included in base fee” on its line and state the amortization schedule in Part B.
- Exclude unplanned same-day coverage activations (§6), optional line items (Part D; see 5.6), and project work (see 5.7).

Part B — Rates and Terms

Item	Response
Base fee basis (per user / per device / flat) and counts assumed (see 5.15)	
Per-user or per-device rate for changes in counts	
Tier 3 block hours per month; rollover (Y/N); overage hourly rate	
Supplemental coverage: annual retainer (160 hours); standalone hourly rate; same-day activation rate and minimum; rollover (Y/N)	
Rate card by engineer level: business hours / after-hours / holiday; minimum billing increment	
After-hours response to Critical Issues included in base fee (Y/N) (see 8.8)	
Project hourly rates by engineer level (§3.4)	
Hardware markup (%) (see 5.17)	
Annual escalator (fixed % or cap) and written notice period	
Pass-through license increase treatment and notice period	
Amortized amounts: schedule and unamortized balance at each contract anniversary (§1, §6)	
Non-cancelable annual tool commitments: tool, annual amount, term dates, and whether transferable to the Organization (Y/N) (see 10.1)	

Part C – HUD Cost Allocation

Item	Response
Lyons Gardens network administration, annual amount (§3.5, §6)	
Allocation methodology (see 5.14)	
Subcontracted component, if any, stated separately (Addendum 1 §1.4)	

Part D – Optional Line Items (excluded from TCO)

Optional item	Pricing	Notes
End-user password manager for all staff (see 6.10)		
Alternate firewall/BDR ownership model (see 1.5, 5.10)		
Proposed §3.5 scope shifts (itemize)		
Network standardization or internet failover (see 6.7)		
Other (itemize)		